Suppose the USB-C charger is made a standard via government imposition. What if there are small devices, such as wristwatches, where the USB-C charger is too bulky?

How will charger standardization be enforced? Who will watch for violations? Will we have customs officials to watch goods shipments to prevent equipment from coming in, which uses any of the forbidden chargers? Will we have the police raid factories looking for violators who produce equipment with the wrong charger? What about individuals who travel abroad and are carrying their own personal equipment, which they promise will not be used in India? What penalties will we impose in all these cases? Will a black market develop for chargers that violate the rule? Will we enforce laws to prevent such developments?

Or is all this too difficult, and we turn to taxation and subsidies? Perhaps we can tax equipment which has the wrong charger and subsidize equipment that has the right charger. That will have its own complex consequences. And, we have to ask, will the gains exceed the (large) welfare cost associated with the use of public funds?

Standardizing chargers for electronic devices is not a particularly important problem! It is a tiny, inconsequential problem. But in this small illustration, we see how government intervention, even in such small problems, rapidly turns into a mess.

What objectives should the state pursue?

As we have seen with a simple problem like USB chargers, it is not easy to choose the problems where we want intervention by the state. The first question in the field of public policy is: *What objectives of public policy are appropriate?* Should the government own or operate an airline? Courts? Restaurants? Watchmaking factories? Parks? Should a government gift money to poor people? Feed poor people? Run hospitals? Outpatient clinics? Factories that make medicines? Factories that make medical instruments? Trucks? Tanks? Standardize chargers?